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How do CEOs communicate on Twitter? A comparative study between Fortune 200 companies and top startup companies

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Abstract

Purpose – The purpose of this paper is to compare Fortune 200 and top startup chief executive officers' (CEOs) communication strategies on Twitter and the effectiveness of these strategies in influencing public engagement. Specifically, guided by the dialogic communication theory and social presence theory, this study explored CEOs' use of dialogic communication, social presence strategies and message tactics. Additionally, public engagement on Twitter measured by total number of likes, retweets and comments was associated with communication strategies utilized by CEOs.

Design/methodology/approach – This study employed the quantitative content analysis. A total sample of 720 posts from 36 CEOs were selected and analyzed. Drawing from prior studies, a coding scheme was developed and employed during the coding process. Two authors of this study served as coders and reached satisfactory inter-coder reliability. A series of χ^2 tests and negative binomial regressions were conducted for data analysis.

Findings – Neither Fortune 200 CEOs nor top startup CEOs fully utilized dialogic principles for Twitter communication. Although Fortune CEOs seemed to be experts in strategically tailoring messages and therefore present themselves on Twitter in a friendly manner, startup CEOs demonstrated a higher level of authenticity, animation and informality. Findings are mixed regarding the direction of associations between dialogic principles and public engagement.

Originality/value – This study expands the application of dialogic principles in examining online executive communication and its influence in public engagement on Twitter. This study was among the first that examined executive leadership communication in the context of social media setting. In this sense, the study shifted the internal focus of leadership research to investigating leaders' interaction with a variety of online publics.

Keywords Dialogic communication, Social media, CEO communication, Leadership, Social presence, Startups

Paper type Research paper

Leadership communication has been established as an important component of internal communication (Men, 2014a, b). Influence on employee attitudes and behaviors as a result of leadership communication remains central in many predominant leadership communication studies (Berger, 2008; Mayfiled and Mayfield, 2017; Men and Bowen, 2017). More recently, scholarly attention has increasingly focused on leadership communication specific to the chief executive officer (CEO) (Alghawi *et al.*, 2014; Tsai and Men, 2016) and their effective use of social media to engage stakeholders and encourage organizational outcomes (Huang and Yeo, 2017; Men *et al.*, 2018). For example, CEOs can now reach more than just their constituency of followers by turning to social media to communicate. Particularly with built-in features that empower message receivers to like, share and repost information, online CEO-generated content has the potential to build conversation, relationships and community (Cherny, 1999).

Insight into CEO social media communication and how publics perceive CEOs is perhaps best viewed through the lens of social presence theory, which emphasizes the communicator's psychological sense of being together with other social actors in a mediated environment (Lee, 2004). Face-to-face communication has been recognized as having the most social presence. More recently researchers have suggested the highly interactive features of social media

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communication such as live video and audio feeds allow similar connection and social presence to face-to-face communication (Gooch and Watts, 2015). A trend has been observed that more and more CEOs are actively and strategically projecting and enhancing their social media presence – presenting themselves as being real, personable and genuine to promote interaction and dialogue with publics (Men *et al.*, 2018).

In addition to social presence theory, Kent and Taylor's (1998) framework for dialogic communication provided theoretical support for this study. Dialogic communication emphasizes an orientation toward relational communication, listening and soliciting feedback (Kent and Taylor, 2002) and informs much of the contemporary literature on communication and stakeholder engagement in the new media landscape. To date, dialogic theory of public relations has evolved to include the full scope of the social media landscape, including blogs and social media, such as Facebook, Twitter and Instagram (Taylor and Kent, 2014).

Previous studies exploring executives on social media primarily reported descriptive data and were initiated by practitioners (e.g. CEO.com and DOMO, 2016; Weber Shandwick, 2015, 2017). To expand the growing body of knowledge in CEO social media communications, this study is one of the first to examine two types of CEOs – Fortune 200 CEOs and top startup CEOs – in order to compare and contrast their different social media communication strategies, and accordingly, offer strategic guidelines as to how they should effectively communicate on Twitter. Specifically, this study compared their use of dialogic principles, social presence strategies and media tactics. In addition, the connections between applying these strategies and the publics' engagement behavior were explored. Ultimately, the comparison between Fortune 200 CEOs and top startup CEOs was drawn considering the fact that startup companies have different internal and external dynamics and characteristics (Chen *et al.*, 2017).

Twitter was selected as the social media platform to conduct this study because, together with LinkedIn, they are the two social media platforms being used most frequently among CEOs (CEO.com and DOMO, 2016). Compared to LinkedIn which is profession- and business-oriented, Twitter is the social platform that enables broader opinion exchange and therefore is a better medium for us to collect mainstream publics' responses to CEOs' messages (Huang and Yeo, 2017).

Literature review

Executive leaders represent unique roles within organizations. The CEO specifically sets the overall direction and tone of the organization (Resick *et al.*, 2009). From long-range visualization, to day-to-day action and implementation, the CEO is ultimately responsible for establishing an organization's strategy, ensuring organizational alignment, and organizing business operations in that effort (Zaccaro, 2001). Public relations scholars and practitioners likewise embrace the critical connection between effective CEO communication and positive organizational outcomes (e.g. Einwiller *et al.*, 2017; Men and Tsai, 2016). For instance, responsive CEOs who communicate with warmth, sensitivity, compassion and sincerity are more likely to generate quality organization-public relationships (Tsai and Men, 2016).

Social media has become an increasingly relevant and cost-effective means to help organizations build their brand and business (Bresciani and Eppler, 2010), as stakeholders increasingly look to social media presence to evaluate an organization's image, reputation (Rode and Vallaster, 2005) and relevance (Venkatesh, 2018). Relatedly, research suggests the impetus for CEOs to cultivate a social presence is increasing as stakeholders become progressively visible online and expect leaders to reciprocate (Weber Shandwick, 2017). Nevertheless, a recent study conducted by CEO.com and DOMO (2016) showed that there were only 36 Fortune 500 CEOs on Twitter in 2016, among which 25 were active. Though complexities such as lack of

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clear governance and guidelines for appropriateness may constrain some executives' online communication (Lee *et al.*, 2006), the existence of CEO blogs and online communication can play an important role in personifying monolithic corporations to stakeholders, increasing customer engagement, and humanizing CEOs as companies' chief engagement officer (Vidgen *et al.*, 2013). Additionally, Lee *et al.* (2008) suggested collaboration, knowledge management, thought leadership, employee engagement and environmental monitoring represent an additional set of opportunities CEOs may realize by utilizing richness and connectedness in their online communication.

Social media usage at startups and large corporations

The strategies CEOs utilize to communicate and the overarching purposes of CEO messaging vary depending on several organizational factors, including size (Evans *et al.*, 2008; Vidgen *et al.*, 2013). Startup organizations generally refer to nascent, small to mid-sized, innovative enterprises that encourage ideas, competition and economic growth (Bresciani and Eppler, 2010; MacVicar and Throne, 1992). Establishing value, maintaining market share and withstanding competitive pressure are critical for startups, thus resources are carefully considered and often constrained (Venkatesh, 2018). Among inherent constraints for many startup organizations, limited time often dictates resources be allocated by order of importance, leaving activities such as communication to be handled in an *ad hoc*, non-strategic manner out of necessity (Venkatesh, 2018).

Unlike larger organizations who can often leverage long-term reputations, human and financial resources to build their brand (Petkova *et al.*, 2008), startups must find creative and cost-effective ways to communicate and engage stakeholders (Chen *et al.*, 2017). While larger organizations leverage mass communication strategies such as national advertising to engage stakeholders and maintain an established reputation (Chen *et al.*, 2017; Rode and Vallaster, 2005), startup organizations often focus on building awareness, knowledge and business outcomes through relationship-based strategies such as attending professional networking, speaking and community events (Bresciani and Eppler, 2010; Chen *et al.*, 2017). To further delve into the differences and similarities of CEO communications at startup and larger organizations in the digital era, this study compares the use and effectiveness of top startup and Fortune 200 CEO's communication strategies on Twitter in engaging the digital-savvy publics.

CEO social media communication strategies

Principles of dialogic communication. Dialogic communication theory was advanced by Kent and Taylor (1998) as a means for organizations to foster and maintain effective dialogues and relationships with their publics through website communication. They outlined the specific principles of dialogic communication: dialogic loop speaks to the ease with which users can seek and obtain information from an organization. Usefulness of information axiomatically refers to the fact that the available information is appropriate and relevant for the needs of the end users. Generation of return visits takes into account the extent to which attractive and useful features are used to entice visitors to return to a website on a regular basis. Ease of interface refers to the intuitiveness and navigability of the website, while the fifth component, conservation of visitors, references the measures taken to encourage users to stay on the site.

Initially developed to guide communicative relationships with publics on websites, the dialogic principles have been extended to explain stakeholder communication across various social media platforms (Arturo *et al.*, 2017; Men *et al.*, 2018; Seltzer and Mitrook, 2007) and disciplines, including environmental activism (Bortree and Seltzer, 2009; Jahng and Lee, 2018), public relations agencies (Thelen *et al.*, 2018), health care (Hether, 2014),

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higher education (McAllister-Spooner, 2012) and non-profit organizations (Lovejoy *et al.*, 2012). Based on the theory of dialogic communication, scholars have also evaluated the role of the CEO in creating stakeholder engagement and its influence on publics' attitudinal and relational outcomes (e.g. Men and Tsai, 2016; Tsai and Men, 2016).

A ten-year review of digital dialogic communication literature reflects that organizations made relatively shallow utilization of the dialogic principles (McAllister-Spooner, 2009). For instance, Saxton and Waters (2014) evaluated the Facebook use of the 100 largest US-based non-profit organizations and found organizations tend to favor a purely informational message strategy over a two-way dialogue. However, little research to date has explored the utilization of dialogic communication by CEOs on Twitter. To extend the body of knowledge on Kent and Taylor's dialogic principles in relation to Fortune and startup CEOs Twitter communication, the following research question is asked:

RQ1. How do Fortune 200 CEOs and top startup CEOs differ in utilizing dialogic principles on Twitter, if any?

Social presence theory. Social presence theory shares with dialogic communication theory underpinnings rooted in interpersonal communication (Arnett, 1994). Social presence theory contemplates the evolution of social presence from a linear characteristic of communication media (Short *et al.*, 1976) to the capacity of communicators to project themselves socially and emotionally as real people in mediated communications (Garrison *et al.*, 2000). Put another way, social presence theory posits that social presence is a subjective perception that can be affirmatively projected through rather than determined by the medium. According to Gunawardena (1995), online interactions foster a sense of community that in turn gives rise to cognitive belief that the mediated communication is social in nature. Thus, public figures, such as CEOs, can much more readily position themselves as connected to their stakeholders through capable, active and strategic enhancement of social presence (Men *et al.*, 2018).

Rourke *et al.* (1999) sought to observe and assess social presence through three communicative metrics and associated indicators that contribute to social presence: affective strategy asserts social presence utilizing the expression of emotions, feelings and mood as the defining characteristics; interactive strategy employs messages that reference and recognize other communication partners by asking questions, agreeing with, showing appreciation for, or support of others; and cohesive strategy, which acts to sustain or build upon a sense of community or group commitment. Applying the framework set forth by Rourke *et al.* (1999) and to provide further insight into the strategies employed by CEOs at startup and Fortune companies to enhance social presence, this study posits the following research question:

RQ2. How do Fortune 200 CEOs and top startup CEOs differ in creating their social presence on Twitter, if any?

Message tactics: appeal, vividness, themes. This study also explores how similar or different Fortune 200 and top startup CEOs are in employing message tactics. Specifically, CEO message appeal, media vividness, tone and themes of posts are evaluated.

Message appeal is guided by the dichotomous proposition that receiver reactions to a message can largely be considered as either rational or emotional (Albers-Miller and Stafford, 1999). Rational message appeals are practical, rooted in the empirical and functional needs of the message recipients and are hallmarked by message presentation that is forthright and objective (Stafford and Day, 1995). Emotional appeals are geared toward actuation of the message recipient's psychological arousal by creating a positive (or negative) feeling (Hawkins *et al.*, 1998). This study drew from Huang's (1997) typology of emotional appeal and categorized joy, love and surprise under positive emotional appeal, and sadness, fear and anger under negative emotional appeal. Building on this scholarship focusing on rational and emotional message appeals, separate studies have also examined

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humor and vision appeals (Chen *et al.*, 2017; Men *et al.*, 2018). Humor messages evoke positive effects through utilization of humor to attract the message recipient (Chen *et al.*, 2017; Huang, 1997). Vision appeals include information about an organization's overall vision, mission and strategy (Chen *et al.*, 2017; Saxton and Waters, 2014).

Message vividness is most commonly expressed in the form of text, photo, graphics, video or even emoticons and ranges from low vividness (text only) to high (e.g. video and audio animation) (Liu *et al.*, 2017). Vivid, graphic experiences are more persuasive, garner greater attention and lead to longer-lasting memories with increased accuracy (Zeff and Aronson, 1999). Prior studies suggest that vividness increases the recipient's arousal level which in turn can influence attitude (De Vries *et al.*, 2012). To arrive at a more nuanced understanding of how Fortune 200 CEOs and top startup CEOs utilize the full range of message tactics, the following research question is offered:

RQ3. How do Fortune 200 CEOs and top startup CEOs differ in employing message tactics (i.e. message appeals, media vividness, tone and themes) on Twitter, if any?

Public engagement

Engagement has extended conceptually to enjoy distinct focus in public relations and social media (Men and Jiang, 2016; Saks, 2006; Wilcox *et al.*, 2013). Successful social media strategies are often measured or evaluated through public engagement within specific contexts (Bortree and Seltzer, 2009). Behaviors on social media such as liking, sharing and commenting are described by Cho *et al.* (2014) as indicative of engagement and actions requisite of time and effort beyond mere viewing. Itemized hierarchically by effort and impact, low (like), moderate (share) and high (comment) are distinguished as three categorical levels of engagement. This study looked into publics' engagement, indicated by the total number of likes, retweets and comments, with both types of CEOs, and asks:

RQ4. How do public engagement behaviors (i.e. replies, retweets, likes) differ for Fortune 200 CEOs and top startup CEOs?

Earlier studies on CEO social media communication (Men and Tsai, 2016) suggest responsive communication style, and expressions of warmth, friendliness, sincerity, empathy and listening, reinforce key components of organization-public relationships and public engagement. Besides, a notable amount of dialogic research connects public relations outcomes such as relationship building (Seltzer and Mitrook, 2007), stakeholder engagement (Rybalko and Seltzer, 2010) and corporate reputation (Ji *et al.*, 2017) to the dialogic process. To explore the contributions of dialogic communication, social presence strategies and message tactics on public engagement, this study asks:

RQ5. How do dialogic principles, social presence strategies and message tactics affect public engagement behaviors on Twitter for Fortune 200 CEOs and top startup CEOs?

Method

Sampling

This study sampled the Fortune CEOs from the renowned top Fortune US companies listed in 2017. For startup CEO selection, the "50 most promising startups" list published by Bloomberg.com in 2017 was adopted[1]. A total of 18 startup CEOs from the list were found active on Twitter. To be consistent, the study selected the same number of CEOs from the top Fortune 200 companies. The authenticity of the CEO accounts was verified based on Twitter's official blue verified badge, CEOs' profile descriptions and the mention of CEOs by other accounts. Regarding the post selection, similar to Rybalko and Seltzer (2010), we coded

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every other post. Going backward chronologically (from December 1, 2017), a total of 20 posts from each CEO were coded. The final sample included 720 posts from 36 CEOs with half posts from each group. In addition, the number of CEOs' followers, accounts they were following, and the total number of tweets were coded and presented in Table I.

Coding scheme

In line with previous studies (e.g. Rybalko and Seltzer, 2010), dialogic communication in this study consisted of four sub-categories: conservation of visitors, generation of return visits,

CEO types	CEO	Company	Twitter handle	No. following	No. of followers	Total tweets
Fortune 200 CEOs	Brian Krzanich	Intel	@bkrunner	16	19,200	267
	Bruce Broussard	Humana	@BruceDBroussard	38	5,085	207
	Chuck Robbins	Cisco	@ChuckRobbins	297	31,200	1,040
	Indra Nooyi	PepsiCo	@IndraNooyi	168	41,900	85
	Jeff Bezos	Amazon	@JeffBezos	NA	399,000	137
	Jonas Prising	Manpower	@JonasPrising	339	6,006	771
	Kent Thirty	DaVita	@KentThiry	400	2,992	430
	Margaret Keane	Synchrony Financial	@SYFMKeane	207	1,013	62
	Mark Hurd	Oracle	@MarkVHurd	70	67,400	513
	Mark T. Bertolini	Aetna	@mtbert	524	16,500	1,799
	Mary Barra	GM	@mtbarra	67	33,500	404
	Michael Dell	Dell Technology	@MichaelDell	3076	1,240,000	3,914
	Mike Jackson	AutoNation	@CEOMikeJackson	870	14,900	3,868
	Robert Iger	The Walt Disney Company	@RobertIger	66	49,700	47
	Satya Nadella	Microsoft Corporation	@satyanadella	210	1,550,000	737
	Steve Collis	AmerisourceBergen	@SteveCollis_ABC	163	340	45
	Steve Easterbrook	McDonald's	@SteveEasterbrk	20	12,000	465
	Tim Cook	Apple	@tim_cook	59	9,120,000	488
Top Startup CEOs	Ashwini Asokan	Mad Street Den	@LadyAshBorg	914	6,734	17,600
	Stephan Schambach	NewStore	@SchambachSays	540	1,922	595
	Rami Essaid	Distil Networks	@ramiessaid	924	3,531	836
	Val Gui	Instamotor	@valgui1	558	230	1,202
	Yvonne Wassenaar	Airware	@ytechdata	147	783	1,743
	Ashod Donikian	Navisens	@ashoddd	1,755	685	11,300
	Meron Gribetz	Meta	@merongribetz	30	2,386	206
	Jo Schneier	Cognotion	@JoSchneier	1,206	646	859
	Amir Rubin	Paracosm	@AmirRubin	549	517	512
	Brett Jurgens	Notion	@bjurgs	517	566	1,102
	Etai Beck	Folloze	@etaibeck	477	338	1,071
	Christopher Pedregal	Socratic	@cjpedregal	154	469	462
	Louay Eldada	Quanergy	@Louel	1,869	1,023	800
	Brian Grey	Remind	@bgrey	252	1,317	1,243
	Jason Aramburu	Edyn	@jasonaramburu	485	1,957	2,451
	Dan Reich	Troops	@DanReich	1,011	2,770	3,665
	Sean Duffy	Omada Health	@seanduffy	618	3,833	1,046
	Sameer Patel	Kahuna	@SameerPatel	704	14,800	41,000

Notes: $n = 36$. Twitter account information retrieved in December 2017

Table I. Account information of Fortune 200 and startup CEOs on Twitter

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dialogic loop and information of interest to stakeholders. Social presence strategies, comprised of affective, interactive and cohesive elements, were adapted from Rourke *et al.* (1999). Media vividness was measured by the inclusion of text, photos/graphics, video and emoticon/emoji. Text-only posts were coded as low vividness. Moderate vividness posts include photos/graphics, and high vividness posts feature video content. Regarding message appeals, the study evaluated rational appeal, emotional appeal, humor and vision appeal adapted from Chen *et al.* (2017) and Huang (1997). Additionally, themes of posts assessed include: company/CEO news and events, industry news and events, company vision/mission/strategies, products and services, thought leadership building, commenting on or sharing political, social issues/news, personal life, general greetings/thanking/holiday wishes, and others. All the above items were coded as 1 being yes and 2 being no. CEO message tone was coded as 1 being positive, 2 being neutral and 3 being negative. Consistent with previous studies (e.g. Men *et al.*, 2018), level of public engagement with CEOs' posts was measured by the number of replies, retweets and likes.

Coding procedure

A coding scheme was developed and employed during the coding process (see Appendix). Two authors of this study served as coders. Based on a random selection, 10 percent of the posts ($n = 72$) were coded in the pretest. The discrepancies were resolved after discussion. The inter-coder reliability was satisfactory (Scott's π ranged from 86 to 100 percent for each category). The two coders independently coded half of the remaining posts in December 2017.

Results

On *RQ1*, overall, Fortune CEOs utilized better dialogic communication than startup CEOs, especially in terms of conservation of visitors $t(708) = -2.21$, $p < 0.05$ and providing information of interest to stakeholders, $t(718) = -7.60$, $p < 0.001$. A series of χ^2 statistics were used to examine if there are significant differences in individual items between the two groups. Findings indicate Fortune CEOs posted more links to their companies' official websites ($f = 59$, 16.4 percent) compared to startup CEOs ($f = 25$, 6.9 percent), $\chi^2\,(1, n = 720) = 15.58, p < 0.001$. In terms of information of interest to stakeholders, Fortune CEOs posted significantly more about company vision/mission/goals ($f_{\text{Fortune}} = 83$, 23.1 percent vs $f_{\text{startup}} = 25$, 6.9 percent), χ^2 $(1,\ n = 720) = 36.65$, $p < 0.001$, summaries of activities of the CEO/company ($f_{\text{Fortune}} = 199$, 55.3 percent vs $f_{\text{startup}} = 135$, 37.5 percent), χ^2 $(1,\ n = 720) = 22.88$, $p < 0.001$ and speech/column ($f_{\text{Fortune}} = 78$, 21.7 percent vs $f_{\text{startup}} = 46$, 12.8 percent), $\chi^2\,(1, n = 720) = 9.98, p < 0.01$.

Even though no difference was found between Fortune and startup CEOs regarding their overall use of dialogic loop and the generation of return visits, some individual items did differ significantly. Posts liked by the CEO, in the startup group ($f = 75$, 20.8 percent), were significantly higher than in the Fortune group ($f = 15$, 4.2 percent), $\chi^2\,(1, n = 720) = 45.71$, $p < 0.001$. Meanwhile, startup CEOs posted more questions to solicit feedback ($f = 11$, 3.1 percent) than Fortune CEOs ($f = 2$, 0.6 percent), χ^2 $(1,\ n = 720) = 6.35$, $p < 0.05$, though neither group had a high percentage of posting. However, Fortune CEOs were found to utilize more hashtags ($f = 174$, 48.35 percent) than startup CEOs ($f = 130$, 36.1 percent), $\chi^2\,(1, n = 720) = 11.02, p < 0.01$. Furthermore, under the generation of return visits category, the mention/@ function was better employed by Fortune CEOs ($f_{\text{Fortune}} = 210$, 58.3 percent vs $f_{\text{startup}} = 163$, 45.3 percent), $\chi^2\,(1, n = 720) = 12.29, p < 0.001$.

Regarding *RQ2*, results showed that Fortune CEOs were better than startup CEOs in applying all three social presence strategies, that is, affective, $t(718) = -4.45$, $p < 0.001$, interactive, $t(718) = -2.40, p < 0.05$ and cohesive strategies, $t(717) = -6.77, p < 0.001$. Under affective strategies, Fortune CEOs ($f = 203$, 56.4 percent) expressed more emotions in their

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posts as compared to startup CEOs ($f = 126$, 35 percent), χ^2 (1, $n = 720$) = 33.19, $p < 0.001$. Additionally, more self-disclosure was found in Fortune CEOs ($f_{\text{Fortune}} = 161$, 44.7 percent vs $f_{\text{startup}} = 133$, 36.9 percent), χ^2 (1, $n = 720$) = 4.51, $p < 0.05$. However, startup CEOs used more humor ($f_{\text{startup}} = 34$, 6.7 percent vs $f_{\text{Fortune}} = 12$, 3.3 percent), χ^2 (1, $n = 720$) = 4.21, $p < 0.05$, even though neither group applied it to a substantial extent. Upon further examination of interactive strategies, the study found that neither group generously engaged in asking publics questions ($f_{\text{Fortune}} = 2$, 0.6 percent vs $f_{\text{startup}} = 9$, 2.5 percent), or explicitly expressed agreement with publics ($f_{\text{Fortune}} = 13$, 3.6 percent vs $f_{\text{startup}} = 25$, 6.9 percent). Nevertheless, startup CEOs had significantly more posts that entail asking publics questions, χ^2 (1, $n = 720$) = 4.52, $p < 0.05$, and expressing agreement, χ^2 (1, $n = 720$) = 4.00, $p < 0.05$. In terms of expressing appreciation or compliment, Fortune CEOs performed better ($f_{\text{Fortune}} = 139$, 38.6 percent vs $f_{\text{startup}} = 60$, 16.7 percent), χ^2 (1, $n = 720$) = 43.34, $p < 0.001$. Further analysis on cohesive strategy showed that tweets posted by Fortune CEOs comprised more inclusive pronouns (i.e. address the groups as we, us, our or group) ($f_{\text{Fortune}} = 122$, 33.9 percent vs $f_{\text{startup}} = 62$, 17.2 percent), χ^2 (1, $n = 720$) = 26.28, $p < 0.001$. Meanwhile, they also applied more vocatives (e.g. addressing publics by name) ($f_{\text{Fortune}} = 246$, 68.3 percent vs $f_{\text{startup}} = 192$, 53.3 percent), χ^2 (1, $n = 720$) = 17.00, $p < 0.001$.

RQ3 delves into different message tactics. Regarding media vividness, overall, posts by Fortune CEOs were more vivid ($M_{\text{Fortune}} = 1.66$, $\text{SD}_{\text{Fortune}} = 0.54$ vs $M_{\text{startup}} = 1.38$, $\text{SD}_{\text{startup}} = 0.50$, $t(491) = 5.68$, $p < 0.01$). In terms of message appeal, both Fortune CEOs ($f = 293$, 81.4 percent) and startup CEOs ($f = 314$, 87.2 percent) primarily used rational appeal, but, in comparison, startup CEOs applied more rational appeal (χ^2 (1, $n = 720$) = 4.63, $p < 0.05$) whereas Fortune CEOs applied more emotional appeal [$f_{\text{Fortune}} = 201$, 55.8 percent vs $f_{\text{startup}} = 138$, 38.3 percent, χ^2 (1, $n = 720$) = 22.13, $p < 0.001$). Moreover, specific emotional appeals such as joy ($f_{\text{Fortune}} = 128$, 35.6 percent vs $f_{\text{startup}} = 91$, 25.3 percent, χ^2 (1, $n = 720$) = 8.98, $p < 0.01$) and love ($f_{\text{Fortune}} = 49$, 13.6 percent vs $f_{\text{startup}} = 8$, 2.2 percent, χ^2 (1, $n = 720$) = 32.03, $p < 0.01$) were featured more heavily in Fortune CEOs' posts. More surprise ($f_{\text{Fortune}} = 3$, 0.8 percent vs $f_{\text{startup}} = 15$, 4.2 percent, χ^2 (1, $n = 720$) = 8.21, $p < 0.01$) and anger ($f_{\text{Fortune}} = 4$, 1.1 percent vs $f_{\text{startup}} = 15$, 4.2 percent, χ^2 (1, $n = 720$) = 6.54, $p < 0.05$) were found in startup CEOs' posts. Additionally, Fortune CEOs utilized more vision appeal ($f_{\text{Fortune}} = 77$, 21.4 percent vs $f_{\text{startup}} = 23$, 6.4 percent, χ^2 (1, $n = 720$) = 33.87, $p < 0.001$) while startup CEOs applied more humor appeal ($f_{\text{Fortune}} = 12$, 3.3 percent vs $f_{\text{startup}} = 24$, 6.7 percent, χ^2 (1, $n = 720$) = 4.21, $p < 0.05$). In terms of the theme of CEOs' posts, findings revealed Fortune CEOs posted more on company/CEO news/events ($f_{\text{Fortune}} = 263$, 73.1 percent vs $f_{\text{startup}} = 152$, 42.2 percent, χ^2 (1, $n = 720$) = 70.09, $p < 0.001$), company vision/mission/strategy ($f_{\text{Fortune}} = 86$, 23.9 percent vs $f_{\text{startup}} = 21$, 5.8 percent, χ^2 (1, $n = 720$) = 46.38, $p < 0.001$), products and service ($f_{\text{Fortune}} = 68$, 18.9 percent vs $f_{\text{startup}} = 43$, 11.9 percent, χ^2 (1, $n = 720$) = 6.66, $p < 0.05$) and greetings/thanking/wishes ($f_{\text{Fortune}} = 12$, 3.3 percent vs $f_{\text{startup}} = 24$, 6.7 percent, χ^2 (1, $n = 720$) = 4.21, $p < 0.05$). Startup CEOs posted more on industry news ($f_{\text{Fortune}} = 11$, 3.1 percent vs $f_{\text{startup}} = 87$, 24.2 percent, χ^2 (1, $n = 720$) = 68.23, $p < 0.001$) and personal life ($f_{\text{Fortune}} = 33$, 9.2 percent vs $f_{\text{startup}} = 51$, 14.2 percent, χ^2 (1, $n = 720$) = 4.37, $p < 0.05$). There was also a significant difference between the two types of CEOs regarding the tone of their posts, χ^2 (1, $n = 720$) = 39.77, $p < 0.001$. Fortune CEOs expressed a more positive tone ($f_{\text{Fortune}} = 269$, 74.7 percent vs $f_{\text{startup}} = 190$, 52.8 percent). In contrast, startup CEOs had more neutral ($f_{\text{Fortune}} = 76$, 21.1 percent vs $f_{\text{startup}} = 134$, 37.2 percent) and negative tone ($f_{\text{Fortune}} = 15$, 4.2 percent vs $f_{\text{startup}} = 32$, 8.9 percent).

Regarding *RQ4*, on average, Fortune CEOs received significantly more likes ($M_{\text{Fortune}} = 1{,}186$, $\text{SD}_{\text{Fortune}} = 4{,}109$ vs $M_{\text{startup}} = 2.56$, $\text{SD}_{\text{startup}} = 5.12$, $t(294) = 4.95$, $p < 0.001$) and retweets ($M_{\text{Fortune}} = 313.46$, $\text{SD}_{\text{Fortune}} = 1{,}361.82$ vs $M_{\text{startup}} = 0.79$,

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$SD_{startup} = 2.80$, $t(294) = 3.94$, $p < 0.001$) from the publics. They did not differ in the number of replies they received ($M_{Fortune} = 210.15$, $SD_{Fortune} = 2{,}795.37$ vs $M_{startup} = 0.30$, $SD_{startup} = 0.67$, $t(491) = 1.06$, $p = 0.29$).

To examine *RQ5* concerning the respective effects of dialogic communication, social presence strategies and message tactics on public engagement, a series of negative binomial regressions were completed (see Tables II–IV)[2]. Conservation of visitors had a negative relationship with number of likes, replies and retweets for both Fortune and startup CEOs. Generation of return visits was negatively related to three engagement indicators for Fortune CEOs and was negatively associated with number of replies for startup CEOs. Similarly, dialogic loop was negatively associated with number of likes and retweets for both and was negatively related to number of replies for Fortune CEOs. However, posting information of interest to stakeholders was positively related to number of likes and retweets for both and was positively related to number of replies for Fortune CEOs.

On social presence, affective strategy was positively related to number of likes and replies for Fortune CEOs and had a negative association with retweets for startup CEOs. Interactive strategy was negatively related to number of retweets and replies only for Fortune CEOs. The study also found a positive relationship between using cohesive strategy and likes for startup CEOs and a positive association between using cohesive strategy and replies for Fortune CEOs.

	Fortune CEO posts ($n = 294$)		Startup CEO posts ($n = 198$)	
	B (SE)	Exp (*B*)	*B* (SE)	Exp (*B*)
Social presence				
Affective strategy	0.25** (0.07)	1.28	0.34 (0.20)	1.40
Interactive strategy	−0.42*** (0.09)	0.66	0.21 (0.20)	1.23
Cohesive strategy	0.36** (0.12)	1.43	−0.30 (0.25)	0.74
Dialogic communication				
Conservation of visitors	−0.1.01*** (0.17)	0.36	−2.60** (0.80)	0.80
Generation of return visits	−0.76*** (0.07)	0.47	−0.41* (0.19)	0.66
Dialogic loop	−0.46*** (0.10)	0.63	−0.34 (0.26)	0.72
Information of interest to stakeholders	0.55*** (0.09)	1.73	0.39 (0.23)	1.48
Message appeal				
Rational appeal	0.51** (0.17)	1.66	−0.30 (0.42)	0.74
Emotional appeal	0.67*** (0.14)	1.96	0.36 (0.33)	1.44
Humor appeal	1.03** (0.31)	2.79	1.00 (0.63)	2.71
Vision appeal	−0.01 (0.16)	0.99	0.13 (0.68)	1.14
Themes of posts				
Company/CEO news and events	0.42* (0.21)	1.52	−0.18 (0.48)	0.83
Industry news and events	−0.63 (0.42)	0.53	−0.79 (0.60)	0.45
Company vision/mission/strategies	0.33 (0.19)	1.40	0.08 (0.72)	1.08
Products and services	0.69*** (0.20)	2.00	0.30 (0.57)	1.35
Thought leadership building	−1.34*** (0.18)	0.26	−0.59 (0.43)	0.56
Commenting on or sharing any political, social issues/news	0.03 (0.22)	1.04	−0.50 (0.68)	0.61
Personal life	0.56* (0.25)	1.74	−0.09 (0.52)	0.91
Greetings/thanking/holiday wishes	−0.13 (0.16)	0.88	−0.99 (0.69)	0.37

Table II.
Negative binomial regression with number of replies as dependent variable

Notes: CEO retweets ($n = 228$) were excluded from the regression analysis because retweets do not measure the engagement received by the CEO, but the engagement received by the original tweet. *$p < 0.05$; **$p < 0.01$; ***$p < 0.001$

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	Fortune CEO posts ($n = 294$)		Startup CEO posts ($n = 198$)	
	B (SE)	Exp (*B*)	*B* (SE)	Exp (*B*)
Social presence				
Affective strategy	0.18* (0.07)	1.19	0.05 (0.11)	1.05
Interactive strategy	−0.15 (0.09)	0.86	−0.02 (0.11)	0.98
Cohesive strategy	0.17 (0.12)	1.18	0.27* (0.12)	1.31
Dialogic communication				
Conservation of visitors	−1.30*** (0.18)	0.27	−1.39*** (0.27)	0.25
Generation of return visits	−0.75*** (0.06)	0.47	−0.01 (0.09)	1.00
Dialogic loop	−0.53*** (0.09)	0.59	−0.68*** (0.15)	0.51
Information of interest to stakeholders	0.58*** (0.09)	1.78	0.50*** (0.12)	1.66
Message appeal				
Rational appeal	2.62*** (0.46)	13.71	1.01*** (0.28)	2.75
Emotional appeal	−1.47** (0.50)	0.23	0.52** (0.18)	1.69
Humor appeal	8.45 (23.77)	4,675.64	0.25 (0.46)	1.29
Vision appeal	−2.52*** (0.46)	0.08	0.26 (0.35)	1.30
Themes of posts				
Company/CEO news and events	0.30 (0.20)	1.35	0.54 (0.31)	1.71
Industry news and events	0.01 (0.40)	1.01	0.15 (0.33)	1.16
Company vision/mission/strategies	0.12 (0.16)	1.31	0.40 (0.36)	1.50
Products and services	0.90*** (0.18)	2.45	0.09 (0.33)	1.09
Thought leadership building	−1.55*** (0.15)	0.21	−0.82*** (0.21)	0.44
Commenting on or sharing any political, social issues/news	0.15 (0.20)	1.61	−0.20 (0.36)	0.82
Personal life	0.50* (0.25)	1.65	−0.28 (0.32)	0.76
Greetings/thanking/holiday wishes	0.25 (0.16)	1.28	−0.77* (0.32)	0.46

Notes: CEO retweets ($n = 228$) were excluded from the regression analysis because retweets do not measure the engagement received by the CEO, but the engagement received by the original tweet. *$p < 0.05$; **$p < 0.01$; ***$p < 0.001$

Table III. Negative binomial regression with number of likes as dependent variable

On message appeal, rational appeal was positively related to number of likes and retweets for both. For startup CEOs, the number of likes they received was positively related to using emotional appeal. Publics were also more likely to reply and retweet posts with emotional appeal from Fortune CEOs despite giving less likes. In addition, humor was associated positively with number of retweets for Fortune CEOs. Themes of the posts matter more for Fortune CEOs compared to startup CEOs in generating public engagement. In general, publics liked and replied more Fortune CEOs' posts related to the company. Media vividness was positively associated with number of likes for both.

Discussion and conclusions

CEO dialogic communication

Neither Fortune 200 CEOs nor top startup CEOs fully utilized dialogic principles for Twitter communication. This is consistent with previous studies which found organizations of various kinds did not take advantage of the opportunities to engage in two-way communication on social media (e.g. Bortree and Seltzer, 2009; Saxton and Waters, 2014). Men *et al.* (2018) also noted that even among the top social CEOs, their use of dialogic communication on Facebook is lacking.

In providing useful information to stakeholders, Fortune CEOs had a better performance than startup CEOs. Specifically, posts of Fortune CEOs were closely related to the company *per se*. For example, interested stakeholders will be more likely to find links to the

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	Fortune CEO posts ($n = 294$)		Startup CEO posts ($n = 198$)	
	B (SE)	Exp (*B*)	*B* (SE)	Exp (*B*)
Social presence				
Affective strategy	0.12 (0.07)	1.13	−0.29* (0.14)	0.75
Interactive strategy	−0.21* (0.08)	0.81	0.09 (0.14)	1.09
Cohesive strategy	0.17 (0.12)	1.18	0.05 (0.17)	1.05
Dialogic communication				
Conservation of visitors	−1.01*** (0.18)	0.37	−1.72*** (0.39)	0.18
Generation of return visits	−0.57*** (0.06)	0.57	0.05 (0.12)	1.05
Dialogic loop	−0.59*** (0.10)	0.55	−0.77*** (0.20)	0.46
Information of interest to stakeholders	0.63*** (0.09)	1.88	0.83*** (0.16)	2.29
Message appeal				
Rational appeal	0.96*** (0.18)	2.62	1.71** (0.52)	5.53
Emotional appeal	0.39** (0.13)	1.48	0.19 (0.24)	1.20
Humor appeal	1.45*** (0.32)	4.25	−0.45 (0.61)	0.64
Vision appeal	0.15 (0.16)	1.16	0.06 (0.45)	1.07
Themes of posts				
Company/CEO news and events	0.56** (0.20)	1.75	0.55 (0.41)	1.74
Industry news and events	0.47 (0.41)	1.61	0.07 (0.45)	1.07
Company vision/mission/strategies	0.39* (0.16)	1.48	−0.21 (0.46)	0.81
Products and services	1.13*** (0.19)	3.10	−0.15 (0.40)	0.86
Thought leadership building	−1.58*** (0.15)	0.21	−0.65** (0.27)	0.52
Commenting on or sharing any political, social issues/news	0.48* (0.21)	1.62	−0.45 (0.52)	0.64
Personal life	0.22 (0.24)	1.24	−1.61** (0.51)	0.20
Greetings/thanking/holiday wishes	−0.11 (0.16)	0.90	−0.70 (0.42)	0.50

Table IV.
Negative binomial regression with number of retweets as dependent variable

Notes: CEO retweets ($n = 228$) were excluded from the regression analysis because retweets do not measure the engagement received by the CEO, but the engagement received by the original tweet. *$p < 0.05$; **$p < 0.01$; ***$p < 0.001$

company's official website, the company's vision, mission, goal and summaries of activities of the CEO/company by following Fortune CEOs on Twitter. Given that one of the primary purposes of branding for startup companies is to raise publics' awareness of their corporate identity (Witt and Rode, 2005), startup CEOs may consider being more strategic in posting more about the company's mission, vision, goal and activities.

In terms of creating dialogic loop, Fortune CEOs were better at using the embedded interactive tools on Twitter such as hashtags and mention/@ functions, indicating that they were more skillful Twitter users who knew what topics they wanted to focus on and who they wanted to engage with. By comparison, startup CEOs liked others' posts more and asked more questions to solicit feedback, showing startup CEOs tend to be more open and informal in dialogue.

CEO social presence

The employment of social presence strategies humanizes CEOs and narrows the psychological distance between CEOs and their publics (Men *et al.*, 2018). In this study, Fortune CEOs utilized better social presence strategies. Specifically, their posts were more affection-oriented, characterized by use of emotional expressions and self-disclosure. They were also more interactive in terms of showing appreciation and compliments. In addition, they were intentional in addressing publics by their names, and through the use of inclusive pronouns such as "we," "us," "our" and "ourselves."

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Although Fortune CEOs seemed to be experts in strategically tailoring messages and therefore present themselves on Twitter in a friendly manner, startup CEOs demonstrated a higher level of authenticity, animation and informality. For instance, startup CEOs used more humor, explicitly expressed personal opinions and openly shared agreement on issues in comparison to the more formal, carefully crafted communications from Fortune CEOs. Top startup CEOs asked more questions which showcased their interest in listening and learning from the Twitter community. Fortune CEOs who face a more diverse range of stakeholders could be well aware of their social impacts and therefore refrained from engaging in informal and casual conversations with other Twitter users. This finding concurred with one study which found that compared to Inc. 500[3] CEOs, most Fortune 500 CEOs used more formal language such as complete sentences and proper grammar (Porter *et al.*, 2015). The authors also noted that top leaders of organizations are suspicious of using social media because of the risks of getting "snarky" comments and losing control (Porter *et al.*, 2015). This partially explains why Fortune CEOs appeared to be more formal, focused on maintaining good organizational images and avoidant of controversies and alienation from their stakeholders, as compared to startup CEOs.

CEO message tactics

Regarding message tactics, Fortune CEOs incorporated more photos/graphics and displayed more vivid messages than startup CEOs. Moreover, more than half of Fortune CEOs capitalized on positive emotional appeal and expressed joy and love in their posts. They also employed more vision appeal. In comparison, startup CEOs exhibited more surprise and anger, and employed more humor appeal.

Findings regarding the themes of the posts are not surprising. Fortune CEOs bear more responsibility as corporate spokesperson and chief engagement officer. They fulfilled this role by tweeting more about their companies. This accords with Porter *et al.*'s (2015) conclusion that Fortune 500 CEOs tweeted more about their companies than the Inc. 500 CEOs. In addition to company-related tweets, they expressed more greetings/thanking/wishes and their tone was more positive, demonstrating their well-contemplated gesture of warmth, care and friendliness.

Startup CEOs, on the other hand, tweeted more industry news. Because startup companies comprised mostly technology firms with a focus on providing high-tech products and services, it is expected that startup CEOs would stay up-to-date with the newest industry trends. Additionally, due to the nature of startup companies, they have no established role or reputation in the marketplace (Petkova *et al.*, 2008), and their survival and growth are highly dependent on policies, investors and market needs which are more fluctuated than traditional industries. This explains why startup CEOs are particularly alert with changes happening in the external environment. Finally, the study found startup CEOs were more straightforward in posting their personal lives, which can be interpreted as using a "friend image strategy" by actively sharing their personal stories and being more relatable with their followers (Alghawi *et al.*, 2014).

Effects of dialogic communication, social presence and message tactics on public engagement

Findings are mixed regarding the direction of associations between dialogic principles and public engagement. Providing information of interest to stakeholders was positively associated with the number of likes and retweets for both types of CEOs. This finding is consistent with previous studies which have identified the significant role of providing relevant information in facilitating social media engagement (Huang and Yeo, 2017; Men *et al.*, 2018; Saxton and Waters, 2014). This suggests that one-way communication could be effective in engaging publics and generating responsiveness among publics if the provided information is useful (McAllister-Spooner and Kent, 2009). Surprisingly, dialogic loop was

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negatively related to public engagement (i.e. likes, retweets). Though seemingly counterintuitive, it was not hard to find that the most salient dialogic features CEOs employed were hashtags and mention functions. Even though hashtags and mention functions are deemed as interactive features which facilitate dialogue, Taylor and Kent (2004) also noted that "facilitating dialogue is not the same as genuine dialogue" (p. 74). In comparison, CEOs rarely posted questions to solicit feedback or requested publics to ask a question or leave a comment, even though these strategies are likely viewed as more genuine, intentional and effective in generating two-way dialogue (Thelen *et al.*, 2018). On conservation of visitors and generation of return visits, they were negatively associated with public engagement indicators in one way or another. Given the fact that most features falling under these two categories include links to other sources, it is likely that clicking into links to other websites or social media diverted the traffic away from Twitter and thus led to less likes, retweets or comments (Men *et al.*, 2018; Thelen *et al.*, 2018).

Regarding the effect of social presence, use of affective strategy effectively enhanced public engagement for Fortune CEOs. CEOs who personified themselves by using emotional expressions, humor and self-disclosure appeared to garner more likes and replies on Twitter. Additionally, by adopting cohesive strategies, Fortune and startup CEOs received more replies and likes, respectively. This finding extends previous studies (e.g. Men and Tsai, 2016) on how responsive leadership communication could foster positive public attitudes and relational outcomes in social media context.

Certain message tactics also contributed to public engagement. Rational appeal was positively related to the number of likes and retweets for Fortune and startup CEOs. This signals publics' interests in attaining objective company/CEO-related information via twitter (Alghawi *et al.*, 2014) and reinforces previous argument that rational appeal enhances message credibility and purchase intention because it introduces product information in a straightforward and logical manner (Stafford and Day, 1995). Emotional appeal, on the other hand, complemented publics' informational needs by providing intimate and personal touch and therefore also enhanced public engagement for both CEOs. The use of humor appeal was positively associated with the number of retweets for Fortune CEOs. This finding is supported by the fact that many viral advertisements use humor appeals (Golan and Zaidner, 2008), suggesting that the use of humor increases retweetability.

Theoretical and practical implications

This study has three theoretical contributions. First, it expands the application of dialogic principles in examining online executive communication and its influence in public engagement on Twitter. Second, the integration of dialogic principles, social presence theory and message tactics is particularly beneficial in gaining a comprehensive picture of CEOs' social media communication style. Future research would benefit from this approach by further investigation of corporate social media communication through the lens of interpersonal communication. Third, it contributes to the growing body of literature on leadership communication. While public relations scholars have explored different aspects of leadership (e.g. Jin, 2010; Men, 2014a, b; Meng *et al.*, 2012), this study was among the first that examined executive leadership communication in the context of social media setting. In this sense, the study shifted the internal focus of leadership research to investigating leaders' interaction with a variety of online publics. Moreover, findings provided much-needed information about communication strategies employed by startup CEOs, which have been largely overlooked in communication literature (Chen *et al.*, 2017).

This study also carries managerial implications for organizational leaders, public relations practitioners and social media managers. First, we proposed a framework to profile CEO social media communication. With this tool, public relations practitioners as

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management counselors can diagnose the effectiveness of current executive social media communication and offer suggestions accordingly. Furthermore, this study provided tailored guidelines for two different types of CEOs. For example, while Fortune CEOs likely garner public engagement by demonstrating affection, startup CEOs are better off adopting a more cohesive strategy. The results also indicate that startup CEOs should post more about company products, mission and vision to establish their corporate identity among publics, which in turn could lead to enhanced corporate image and reputation (Witt and Rode, 2005). Finally, it is advisable that both Fortune and startups CEOs demonstrate authentic two-way communications by engaging in meaningful discussions with publics. Public relations practitioners need to be aware of the developmental stage of their company and serve as executive counselors to offer advice on how to strategize social media content and messages based on what publics prefer.

Limitations and future directions

This study has several limitations that should be addressed in future research. First, due to the inherent methodological limits of content analysis, this research cannot draw causal relationship between CEO communication strategies and public engagement behavior. Future researchers can conduct surveys and experiments to explain the mechanism of these relationships. Second, public engagement measures adopted in this study do not tell the full story of publics' attitudes and behaviors toward the CEO and the company. To address this issue, future researchers could conduct interviews to examine whether interactions with executives on social media affect publics' belief, attitude or behavior. Third, sample of this study was drawn from Fortune 200 CEOs who represent the top executives of the largest companies in the USA. However, they are not necessarily the CEOs who exhibit the best practice of social media communication. In the future, scholars can identify the practice of top social CEOs on Twitter and draw lessons from them. Finally, many social networking tools are unique in their own way. In order to gain a holistic picture of the executive social media communication, researchers should also examine other social media platforms such as LinkedIn and internal SNS and develop specific communication toolkits for each social platform.

Notes

1. This list published by Bloomberg.com is based on Quid, a market research company. Their inclusion criteria include being founded in the past six years; having been raising money typically once every nine months; having already raised three rounds.
2. This analysis was favored over the linear regression and Poisson regression analysis because our dependent variables (i.e., likes, retweets, comments) are overly dispersed and do not fall under a normal distribution. We controlled the number of followers in running the analyses.
3. The Inc. 500 is an annual list of the 500 fastest-growing private companies in the USA. Inc. 500 has "contrasting levels of size, wealth, and risk" compared to Fortune 500 (Porter *et al.*, 2015, p. 277).

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(The Appendix follows overleaf.)

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Appendix. Coding scheme

I. Basic Information

1. Name of CEO: _____
2. Date of post: _____
3. Time of post: _____
4. Type of post:
   1. Original 2. Reply 3. Retweet 4. "RT" and comments

II. CEOs' Social Media Engagement Strategies

1. Dialogic Principles

All items were coded as 1 being yes and 2 being no.

Conservation of visitors

1. Link to the company's official website
2. Link to other social networks in which the CEO or the company is present (LinkedIn, Facebook, Flickr, YouTube, blogs, Instagram)

Generation of return visits (informativeness)

3. Links to (not necessarily corporate website) websites where additional information can be obtained
4. Links to news related to the CEO or the company issued by external media/source
5. Links to discussion forums and FAQs on the company's website
6. Links to other social networks to introduce information (LinkedIn, Facebook, Flickr, YouTube, blogs, Instagram)
7. Option to request information
8. Links to other Twitter pages: @function

Dialogic loop

9. Reply by the CEO to a user's post
10. Like by the CEO to a user's a post
11. The provision of surveys for users to express opinions on the company
12. The use of hashtags or cashtags
13. Request to ask a question or leave a comment (request can be done via text/video)
14. Questions posted by the CEO to solicit feedback
15. CEO tagging someone to engage in a conversation

Information of interest to stakeholders

16. Press releases (company news, product news)
17. Statement of the company's vision/mission/goals
18. Details of how to participate in activities or events organized by the organization or in which the organization is present
19. Summaries of activities of the CEO or the company
20. Speeches (text, audio or video)/column by anyone in the company

2. Social Presence (Check all that apply)

All items were coded as 1 being yes and 2 being no.

Affective

1. Emotional expressions
   Emotional expressions including descriptions, emoticons :-), repetitious punctuation (!!!), all-cap (HAPPY). Keywords: Sad, shocked, happy, angry, upset, disappointed, pleased, excited, love, fear, nervous, sorry

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2. Humor
   Teasing, iron, sarcasm, joke, code only if it is clearly meant to be funny. Including LOL, haha
3. Self-disclosure
   Details of personal life, or express personal opinion, including feelings of vulnerability. (E.g., I just don't understand how you can treat someone like that.)

Interactive

4. Continue conversation; refer explicitly to others' messages
   Direct references to contents of others' posts, or to quote others' posts; Recognition that another user's message has been the motivation of this message
5. Ask questions
6. Express appreciation/compliment
   E.g. We have the most socially responsible users and customers. or Thank you all your support.
7. Express agreement

Cohesive

8. Address publics by name/@
9. Use inclusive pronouns
   Address the group as we, us, our, group, community, society, country. E.g., The task falls on our shoulders…
10. Phatic/salutations
    Communication that serves a purely social function, greetings, sharing what the CEO is up to at the very moment. E.g., 1) Happy Earth Day. 2) We are having the most beautiful weather here. 3) @Orlando airport. On my way to NYC for the Arthur Page Meeting

3. Media vividness (Type/Format of Posts)
All items were coded as 1 being yes and 2 being no.

- Text
- Photo/Graphics (including GIF)
- Video (recorded)
- Emoticon/emoji

Media vividness: 1_Low 2_Moderate 3_High
Low vividness: Only text
Moderate vividness: Only audio or photos/graphics
High vividness: Videos (since they include both audio and animation)

4. Theme/Topics of Posts (check all that apply)
All items were coded as 1 being yes and 2 being no.

1. Company/CEO news and events
2. Industry news and events
3. Company vision/mission/strategies
4. Products and services
5. Thought leadership building (e.g., sharing industry insights; this does not focus on the company or products, but the bigger picture of the industry)
6. Commenting on or sharing any political, social issues/news (expressing personal opinion)
7. Personal life (e.g. posting a family picture)
8. General greetings/thanking/holiday wishes
9. Other (If other, specify) _____

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5. Message Appeals

All items were coded as 1 being yes and 2 being no.

- Rational (Functional)
- Emotional
    - Positive
        - Joy (excitement, pleasure)
        - Love (longing, arousal, love)
        - Surprise
        - Other
    - Negative
        - Sadness (agony, sadness, shame)
        - Anger (irritation, anger, disgust)
        - Fear (fear, anxiety)
        - Other
- Humor
- Vision
- Other

6. Tone of CEO Posts

1. Positive
2. Neutral
3. Negative (Note: sarcasm is generally perceived as negative)

III. Level of Engagement Behavior

Number of Replies____
Number of Retweets____
Number of Likes___

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